



THE FOREST LINE CHALLENGE

A problem brief for builders — not a spec, a mess worth solving.

The situation (read this twice)

Kenya is the world's biggest exporter of black tea. We grow it, we pick it, we sell it raw at auction in Mombasa — and then someone else in London, Dubai or Cairo packs it, brands it, and sells it for 5–10x what we got paid. We do the hard part. Someone else keeps the money.

The UK alone drinks enormous amounts of tea every year, and buyers there — like buyers across Europe — are asking harder questions about where their tea comes from and how it was grown. That pressure is only going one direction. Whoever can prove their tea is legitimate, traceable, and doing good in the world has an edge with these buyers. Right now, almost nobody in Kenya's tea industry can prove that convincingly.

At the same time, there's a 940 km strip of forest along Kenya's biggest water towers — Mau, Aberdares, Mt Kenya — that's been kept alive for 40 years by planting tea along the forest edge. It works: satellites show the forest coming back where this buffer exists. But growing that buffer needs money, and the people who pluck the tea on it are some of the worst paid in the whole industry — and it's worse on one side of the country than the other, for reasons nobody's fully solved.

So there are three problems tangled into one:

1. **The forest buffer needs to grow**, but it's funded by tea prices that go up and down with nothing to do with conservation.
2. **The farmers who protect that forest edge are underpaid** — especially in the west of the country, where pay can be nearly half what farmers get in the east, for the same work.
3. **Nobody buying the tea has any way to know or care** that their cup is connected to any of this. There's no proof, no story, no reason to pay more.

And underneath all three: **there's currently no way to prove any of it is true**. No verified data. No tamper-proof record. Just claims.

Your challenge

We're not going to tell you what to build. That's the point.

Problem statement:

How might we use technology to turn a real, physical conservation asset (a forest buffer) into something that's provable, fundable, and valuable enough that farmers get paid more, the forest keeps growing, and someone buying a product actually cares?

That's it. That's the brief. Everything below is context to help you dig, not a spec to follow.

What "winning" looks like

We're not scoring on how polished your UI is. We're scoring on:

- **Does it solve a real piece of the problem** — not a vague "blockchain for good" pitch, but something that moves one of the three numbers above?

- **Could it actually work in Kenya** — with spotty connectivity, feature phones still in use, farmers who may not have smartphones, M-Pesa as the only payment rail that matters?
- **Is the proof real** — if you're claiming something is "verified," how? What stops someone faking it?
- **Would someone pay for it** — a farmer, a company, a buyer, a government. Who, and why would they actually pay rather than just say it's a nice idea?

You can go narrow and deep (solve ONE of the three problems really well) or wide and rough (sketch how all three connect). Both are valid. We want to see how *you* think, not whether you guessed our plan.

Areas worth researching (pick a lane, or cross a few)

Proof & verification

- Satellite imagery for tracking land use over time (Sentinel-2 is free, EU-run, 10m resolution)
- How do you prove a tree was planted AND survived — not just planted once and forgotten?
- What makes a claim "tamper-proof"? Look into how carbon credit projects have been caught faking data — what would you do differently?

Money that actually reaches farmers

- M-Pesa / Daraja API for direct payments — how would you pay a farmer a bonus that's tied to something being verified, automatically, without a human approving it manually?
- Look into how tea farmers currently get paid (via factories, via auction) — where does the money leak or slow down?

Low-bandwidth, low-tech-access design

- Most farmers are not on flashy smartphone apps. What does "verified proof" look like on a feature phone, or with someone else scanning on their behalf?
- USSD, SMS-based systems — still huge in rural Kenya

Export compliance (the boring but critical bit)

- The EU and UK increasingly require proof that farm products aren't linked to deforestation — look into what buyers are now asking exporters to demonstrate
- What would make a buyer in Europe or the UK actually trust a claim coming from a small Kenyan exporter, rather than just taking their word for it?
- Look into who Kenya's tea competitors are (India, Sri Lanka, Malawi) — are any of them already doing something on traceability that Kenya isn't?

Making a consumer care

- Why do people pay more for "fair trade" or "organic" labels — and why do some of those labels lose trust over time?
- What's the simplest way someone buying a product could see, in 5 seconds, real proof of impact — not just a logo?

The fairness problem

- Why would pay for the same work differ so much by region? Is it really just geography, or something structural (factory ownership, auction access, bargaining power)?
- What would a "fair pay" system look like that doesn't just throw money at the problem but ties it to something provable?

The money angle nobody's talking about yet

- Companies listed on Kenya's stock exchange are heading toward a hard deadline: real ESG reporting, checked by

independent auditors, is becoming mandatory in stages over the next few years — and right now, almost none of them are ready for it.

- Only a handful of Kenya's ~63 listed companies currently publish anything close to a real, audited sustainability report. Everyone else is going to need one, fast, and most have no idea how to produce credible data.
 - That means there's a real, dated, provable gap: whoever can help a company go from "we have no data" to "we have verifiable proof we can hand an auditor" solves a problem real companies will pay for — soon, not hypothetically.
 - Dig into: what does an investor or auditor actually need to see to trust an ESG claim? What's the difference between a company *saying* something and *proving* it?
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Real numbers to anchor your thinking (not fictional — this is live)

- Kenya's tea buffer belt: **940 km**, spanning **9 forests**, **17 counties**
- Roughly **12,000 people** earn a living directly from this belt — about **60% women**
- Documented pay gap: farmers in the west of the belt have earned as little as **half** what farmers in the east earn, for the same crop
- The EU's deforestation rules (EUDR) are already forcing Kenyan exporters to prove where their product comes from — or lose access to European buyers
- Kenya loses enormous value exporting tea raw instead of packaged and branded — this is not a hypothetical, it's the actual structure of the industry today

- Kenyan-listed companies are on a clock: real sustainability reporting, checked by outside auditors, is becoming mandatory over the next few years — and today, only a small handful of the ~63 listed companies are anywhere close to ready
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What to bring / what "done" looks like

Doesn't need to be a working app. A sharp, well-argued:

- Rough prototype (even paper sketches + a working piece of logic)
- A clear explanation of WHO pays for this, WHO benefits, and WHY it's provable
- Your honest list of what would break this idea in the real world

We'd rather see one real insight than ten shallow features.

Go find the gaps. Surprise us.

Questions? Drop them in the group — we'll answer without giving away the plan.